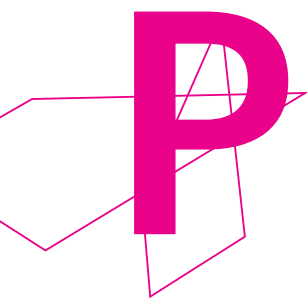


IMMERSIVE ENTERTAINMENT

The metaverse is driving innovative ways of delivering various forms of entertainment, but a lack of regulatory framework is leaving stakeholders worried

BY NIDHI SINGAL

ILLUSTRATION BY NILANJAN DAS



UNJABI SINGER DALER MEHNDI has always attracted big crowds. This January, when he had his debut concert in the metaverse, 20 million people logged in at once, crashing the servers. The event was held on PartyNite, one of India's first metaverse spaces. With this, Mehndi became the first Indian artiste to join the likes of Travis Scott, Justin Bieber and Ariana Grande, who have all had concerts in the metaverse.

In May, media and entertainment (M&E) major Zee inaugurated its Technology and Innovation Centre in Bengaluru, which brings together the relevant skills and resources to help it enter the Web 3.0 universe. Called 'Zeeverse', it is expected to be launched early next year. "Our metaverse will not only facilitate a new way of consuming and engaging with content, but also create new interactive social and commercial experiences within. It will combine the physical and digital experiences for our audiences," says Nitin Mittal, President of Technology and Data at Zee Entertainment Enterprises. In June, telecom major Airtel launched a metaverse multiplex—a 20-screen platform where it plans to offer content from leading OTT partners.

It's not just media and telecom companies that are flocking to the metaverse. GSK Consumer Healthcare's antacid brand ENO, for instance, has created India's first-ever stand-up comedy event there to celebrate 50 years of its presence in India.

